Kathmandu

The big idea

In this extract from his travelogue ***Heaven Lake***, **Vikram Seth** describes his visit to **Kathmandu**, Nepal, at the end of a long journey through Tibet. He contrasts two holy places, a feverish **Hindu** temple and a calm **Buddhist** stupa, and paints the noisy, colourful bazaars of the city before he decides to go home.

TRAVELOGUE

A **travelogue** is a first-person account of a journey, full of descriptive details of places, people, sounds and smells, along with the writer's reflections.

Pashupatinath: an atmosphere of feverish confusion

- The famous **Hindu temple** on the banks of the **Bagmati** river, where **only Hindus** may enter; a sign says so.
- Priests, hawkers, devotees, tourists, **cows, monkeys and pigeons** crowd the place. A **Westerner** is stopped by a policeman because he is not a Hindu (he may not enter).
- **Two monkeys** fight; one chases the other onto a **Shivalinga** and then into the temple.
- On the river bank, a body is being **cremated**, washerwomen are at work, children bathe, and someone throws a basket of dead flowers and leaves into the river.
- A **small shrine half-protrudes** from a stone platform. It is believed that when it fully emerges, the goddess inside will escape and the **evil period of the Kaliyug will end**.

Baudhnath: a haven of quietness

- The **Buddhist stupa** with its immense white dome, ringed by a road of small shops, many run by **Tibetan immigrants** selling felt bags, Tibetan prints and silver jewellery.
- There is **no crowd** and a sense of **stillness**: a haven of quietness amid the busy streets.

THE CENTRAL CONTRAST

Pashupatinath = noise, rituals, crowds, animals, confusion.
Baudhnath = calm, simplicity, peace.
Both are holy, yet they feel completely different.

The bazaars of Kathmandu

- The city is **vibrant, commercial and unholy**: fruit sellers, flute sellers, hawkers of postcards; shops selling Western cosmetics, film rolls and chocolate; car horns, bicycle bells, stray cows, radios blaring film songs.
- Seth treats himself: he eats a **bar of marzipan**, a **corn-on-the-cob roasted** on a charcoal brazier, drinks **Coca-Cola** and an orange drink, and reads *Mad* magazine and other cheap books.
- Feeling **exhausted and homesick**, he imagines an adventurous overland journey home but decides to buy a **ticket for a flight to Delhi** instead.

The flute seller

- In the square near his hotel, a **flute seller** stands with a pole full of about fifty or sixty bamboo flutes, playing slowly and meditatively.
- The music reminds Seth that the **flute is a universal instrument**: every culture has one, from the **Indian bansuri** to the Western flute, the Japanese **shakuhachi** and the Latin American **reed pipes**. The flute's sound, shaped by human breath, makes him think of the "common humanity" of all people.

WHO WAS BARRED FROM THE TEMPLE?

The Westerner was stopped from entering Pashupatinath because only Hindus are allowed inside, not because he lacked a ticket.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Contrast Pashupatinath and Baudhnath. What belief is linked to the small shrine on the Bagmati? Describe the flute seller. How does the author spend his time in the bazaar? Use sensory details in answers.

Quick recap

- Pashupatinath: feverish confusion; Baudhnath: haven of quietness.
- Bazaars: noisy, colourful, commercial.
- Flute seller: music as a universal human language; author flies home to Delhi.

Practice questions

1. "Kathmandu" is an extract from Vikram Seth's
   (a) A Suitable Boy (b) The Golden Gate (c) Heaven Lake (d) From the Himalayas
2. The atmosphere at Pashupatinath is described as one of
   (a) feverish confusion (b) quiet devotion (c) complete silence (d) royal splendour
3. On which river's bank is Pashupatinath situated?
   (a) Ganga (b) Koshi (c) Gandak (d) Bagmati
4. What will happen, according to belief, when the small shrine fully emerges from the platform?
   (a) The temple will collapse (b) The river will dry up (c) The evil period of the Kaliyug will end (d) A new king will be crowned
5. Baudhnath stupa is described as
   (a) noisy and crowded (b) a haven of quietness (c) a place only for Hindus (d) a modern shopping mall
6. How does the author finally decide to return home?
   (a) By bus to Patna (b) On foot over the mountains (c) By flight to Delhi (d) By boat down the Ganga
7. Contrast the atmosphere at Pashupatinath with that at Baudhnath.
8. What thoughts does the flute seller's music bring to the author's mind?

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. c 5. b 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes